

ALAMY

Burqa

The most intense covering, it includes a full-body cloak, a veil for the face and a covering for the head, as well as a screen covering the eyes



Chador

A large piece of cloth that is used as a combination shawl/ head covering and face veil

These are only some variations; others include the *shayla* (a long scarf that is used to cover the head and face) and the *abaya* (a long robe-like dress that is usually worn over the clothing). While it is common to see such clothing in black, the colour is not fixed—in Afghanistan, for instance, *burqa*s are often in a shade of blue. The exact cut and style also vary, keeping in mind local customs and climate, alerting us to their evolution in response to cultural and geographic compulsions.

19), to Freedom of Religion (Art. 25), to minority rights (Art. 29). Indeed, under Art. 25, the explicit sanction for the Sikh kirpan in Clause (2)(b)—which protects Sikhs from such state intrusions—can be interpreted as an *illustrative* 'Explanation'. The state responded with a hastily-crafted government order, decreeing a ban on clothes that "disturb equality, integrity and public order" in public schools and PU colleges. Without specifics, it declared that "a uniform style of clothes has to be worn compulsorily". This conferred official sanction ex post facto on the college's uniform—which otherwise was at odds with the original 1983 Act. In effect, it was a ban on the hijab. As 17-year-old Aliya Assadi, one of the original sorority of six, described it to INDIA TODAY plaintively, what was deemed a threat to 'public order' was "just a headscarf, colour-coordinated with our uniform, not covering the face". Now it had been outlawed as if it was some totem of terror.

Before you knew it, a slew of Udupi government colleges, some of whom had earlier allowed the hijab without demur, started ostracising scarved Muslim girls—stopping them at the gates, or making them sit in separate classrooms. National channels started flashing images of hapless girls pleading with their teachers and principals, in vain. Frustration boiled over. At this point, the hijab protests, shadowed by the choreography of anger in saffron, now spread like wildfire across Karnataka districts—Shivamogga, Vijayapura, Gadag, Dakshina Kannada, Davangere, Mysuru, Chitradurga. In Mandya, a lone girl named Muskan became a national meme, facing up to a slogan-shouting mob of saffron-clad boys. State BJP chief and MP Nalin Kateel, a coastal native himself, said Karnataka would not allow "Talibanisation". With tensions riding high, the state closed high schools and colleges for three days.

But the contagion had by now spread to the north—copycat protests were seen in Maharashtra, Hyderabad, Kolkata, Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh. The tinderbox-like spaces of social media were abuzz, especially in election-eve Uttar Pradesh. A DMK MP raised the issue in Parliament. The Prime Minister alluded to it. Lawyers, theologians, activists and ordinary people debated it furiously. Unhelpfully, even the real Taliban issued a statement. The cynosure of all eyes now: the legal battle unfolding in the Karnataka HC where the BJP state government, headed by a former socialist who now lip-syncs his new party's lines like a practised thespian, is also one of the disputants.

The core questions at stake are themselves disarmingly simple. Should Muslim girls who choose to wear the Islamic headscarf be debarred from education in public schools and PU colleges? Do state-run educational institutions have the mandate to legislate student attire in a manner that it outlaws any manifestation of religion—visible over and above a stipulated uniform? Was the Udupi college's stand—a de facto ban only on the hijab, since other manifestations of